

II

A PRACTICE GUIDE FROM THE HUSH ROOM

The *Examen.*

Daily Review · Where was God present today?



*A prayerful walk back through your day — looking for where God was present,
where you missed Him, and where He is calling you tomorrow.*

"In him we live and move and have our being."

Acts 17:28

THE PRACTICE

Examining the day with God.

Ignatius of Loyola, in 1522, was developing what he called the Spiritual Exercises — a structured way to help anyone, not only monks, walk closely with God. He included one prayer intended to be prayed even when life was so busy that other prayers became impossible. He called it The Examen.

The word comes from Latin and means an accurate assessment of the true situation. It is the simplest form of contemplative prayer: at the end of the day, you ask the Holy Spirit to walk you back through the hours just lived, and you look — together with God — for what He was doing.

Ten to fifteen minutes is enough. The point is not to produce a spiritual journal. The point is to train the eyes of your heart to see God in your ordinary day.

Jesus is always watching for the movements of his Father, so that He can join Him in what He is doing.

Richard Foster describes the Examen as a door with two sides. One side is the examen of consciousness — where God was present and how we responded. The other side is the examen of conscience — where we resisted Him and what needs to be brought into the light. Both sides matter. Most days, you will need both.

THE FIVE MOVEMENTS

Ignatius's pattern, in plain language.

Find a quiet space. Turn off your phone. Sit comfortably. Breathe out. Then move slowly through these five steps.

i. Recall

You are in the presence of God.

Renew your awareness of God's love for you. He is your Father. He has been with you all day, even when you were not aware of Him. Ask the Holy Spirit to guide your heart and mind as you look back.

ii. Gratitude

Review your day with thanksgiving.

Walk through the day from beginning to end. Not analytically — gently. What did you receive? Where did you see God's goodness, beauty, or mercy? Who showed up for you? Where did you feel most alive?

Take time to thank Him for each. Even small things. Especially small things.

iii. Review

Look at your heart.

Now ask honestly: where did you resist God today? Where were you short with someone, harboured bitterness, walked past someone in need, justified yourself? What patterns made you more like Christ today? Less?

Let God show you. Trust Him not to allow you to look away. Trust Him also not to shame you. He does not condemn — He illumines, so that what is hidden can be brought into the light and healed.

iv. Renew

Receive forgiveness and grace.

If you have placed your faith in Christ, you are reviewing your day from inside His love, not outside it. You are not earning approval. You already have it. You are simply looking — with the Father — at what was, so that what comes next can be different.

Repent of what needs repenting. Receive the grace already given.

v. Look Forward

Pray the Lord's Prayer.

End by praying with Jesus, in the words He taught: Our Father in heaven, holy is your name. Your kingdom come, your will be done. Give us today our daily bread. Forgive us our debts, as we have forgiven our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil. Amen.

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

When the five movements feel abstract.

If you find yourself stuck during the Review, try one or two of these. Not all at once — pick what fits the day:

- For what or whom am I most grateful today?

- For what or whom am I least grateful?
- Where did I show God's love today? Where did I fail to?
- When did I feel most alive? Most distant from God?
- What pattern made me more like Christ today? What pattern made me less?
- Is there a relationship I need to take a step toward restoring?
- Is God asking me to start something? To stop something?
- Is God asking me to start believing something? To stop?

A note: The Examen is best practised in the evening, when the day is still fresh. But there is no rule. Some pray it at lunch, some in the morning over the day before, some weekly. The rhythm that matters is the one you can keep.

A blessing as you begin.

*May you learn to see your ordinary days
as Jesus saw His — full of His Father's movements.*

*May the eyes of your heart be opened
to the presence that has never left you,
and to the grace that meets you in the truth.*

The Father waits. The Son welcomes. The Spirit moves.